ing the detention system. The Mamata Banerjee-led administration's receptiveness is evident in its adoption of the three-language policy. But Hindi is a touchy point. Prof. Tarun Kanti Naskar, general secretary of the All India Save Education Committee, described the NEP-in-disguise thus: "Hindi is not mandatory in the NEP, but the Centre has left no doubt that it is the only third optional language. Bengal has done nothing to protest, unlike Tamil Nadu."

The NCERT texts are another front in the battle, the provocation starting with the titles themselves. For instance, the Standard VI and VII English textbooks are named 'Poorvi' as against the previous 'Honeysuckle' and 'Honeycomb', respectively, while the math text has been rechristened 'Ganit Prakash'. A flummoxed Kerala government says this is "against federal principles and constitutional values" and a bid to "foist Hindi on Malayalis". The NCERT has also drawn flak for dropping all references to the Mughals and the Delhi Sultanate in the Standard VII textbooks, while adding references to obscure Indian dynasties, the Kumbh Mela, 'sacred geography' and central initiatives like 'Make in India'. Critics have panned the attempt to airbrush and politicise history under the guise of decolonisation.

An NCERT official, however, says the new language texts were named after 'pan-Indian' musical instruments, ragas and concepts such as Bansuri, Malhaar, Sarangi and Khyal. Most would point out that the northward tilt fairly shines through, but the official says this nomenclature aligns with NEP's vision of embracing joyful learning, cultural rootedness and integration of arts and music into education.

MIGRATORY PATTERNS

The official push for Hindi comes at a time when economic migration from the economically weak Hindi-speaking states is growing, thus leading to a rising presence of this linguistic cohort across India. In Maharashtra, for instance, the 2011 census revealed that, in Mumbai, respondents identifying Hindi as their mother tongue had grown by around 40 per cent from 2.6 million in 2001 to around 3.6 million. The Marathi *manoos* is still the city's largest ethno-linguistic group, but their numbers fell from 4.5 million in 2001 to 4.4 million in 2011.

In fact, the saturation in urban centres like Mumbai has led to many north Indians shifting to smaller towns and even villages where they work in hotels, restaurants and as labour in industries and farms. This has led to nativist parties like the Shiv Sena and the MNS choosing to focus their energies on opposing Hindi speakers.

Former IAS officer, author and president of the state language advisory committee Laxmikant Deshmukh has written to Fadnavis opposing the move to make Hindi mandatory from Class I. He considers the imposition "a cultural attack on Marathi by the Hindi speakers" while pointing out how the migrants, largely, do not

3 LANGUAGES AND A FORMULA

- **The University Education Commission (1948-49), under S. Radhakrishnan proposes the three-language formula for primary and secondary education**
- **In 1966, the Indian Education Commission under D.S. Kothari endorses formula. Implemented via National Education Policy, 1968**
- **The National Education Policy 2020 mandates that from primary classes students must learn three languages, two Indian ones and English**
- **Tamil Nadu has gone to court over NEP. Maharashtra's BJP government brought a resolution making Hindi compulsory, but it didn't last**

2025 FLASHPOINTS

- **MAHARASHTRA: MNS chief Raj Thackeray warns bank workers, says they must converse in Marathi; party workers visit bank branches, intimidate staff**
- **On Apr. 22, state government backs down on move to make Hindi mandatory in Class I-V**
- **TAMIL NADU: CM M.K. Stalin alleges the NEP was not created to help the country, but to propagate Hindi, claims it will ruin the state's education system**
- **Deputy CM Udhayanidhi Stalin says NEP, three-language formula and NEET are out to undermine Tamil**
- **PUNJAB: AAP government makes Punjabi mandatory subject for all schools/boards**
- **TELANGANA: State government says Telugu will be made mandatory for all schools**
- **KARNATAKA: CM Siddaramaiah says committed to two-language policy, will not allow imposition of Hindi. Sporadic protests against Hindi signages in state**
- **KERALA: Education minister V. Sivankutty blasts NCERT's use of Hindi titles for English-medium texts**